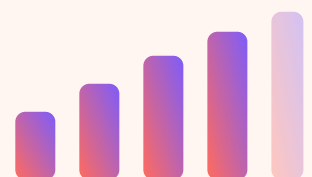


• FREE EDUCATIONAL GUIDE

How to start investing

The essentials gathered in one place —
made for people who are truly just
starting.

No products.
No promises.



ABOUT THIS GUIDE

Everything you need to take the first step — without the noise.

This ebook brings together, in one place, the core ideas for anyone truly starting to invest. It is organised into short modules, from the right mindset to building your first plan. Read in order or jump to what you need — it is all open.

We sell nothing and make no promises of return. Examples are always by *asset class*, never specific products.

7

guided modules

~75

minutes of reading

0

products sold

IMPORTANT NOTICE

Purely educational content about financial literacy. Nothing here is financial, investment, tax or legal advice, nor a recommendation to buy or sell. Investing involves risk, including the possible loss of capital. Past performance does not guarantee future results. Examples are illustrative and by asset class only. Before deciding, consider your own situation and, if needed, seek independent professional advice.

Contents

HOW TO START INVESTING

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How to use this guide

Read in order if you are truly starting — each module builds on the last. If you already know the basics, jump to what interests you. There are no deadlines: go at your own pace.



KEY IDEA

The sentence to take from each chapter. If you only read this, you have already gained something.



EXAMPLE

An illustrative case, always by asset class — never a specific product.



CAUTION

A common mistake or a trap to avoid before it costs you money.



TERM

An underlined word you will find explained in the glossary, at the end of the guide.

THE PATH

Seven modules, one idea at a time

~75 min total

00

01

02

03

04

05

06

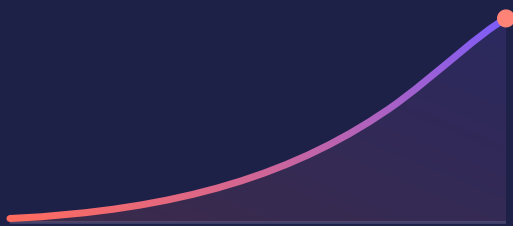
Saving protects. Investing grows.

Setting money aside is the first step, and it is essential — it is your safety net. But idle money loses value every year, eaten away by inflation. Investing means putting part of that money to work, so time plays for you instead of against you.

You do not need to be an expert, to have a lot of money, or to predict the market. You need to understand a handful of ideas and be consistent. That is exactly what this guide gives you.

THE POWER OF TIME

Compound interest works while you sleep



The earlier you start, the less effort the rest demands.

OUR PROMISE

No products. No promises.

- ✓ We sell nothing and take no commissions.
- ✓ We never promise returns or tell you what to buy.
- ✓ We only explain the basics, in plain language.

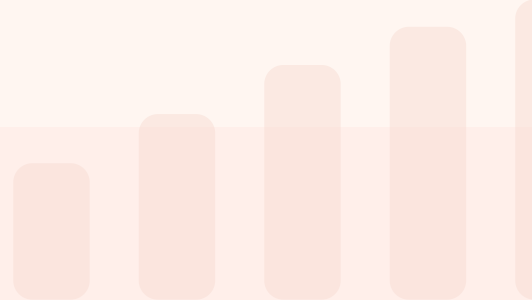
KEY IDEA

Investing well is, above all, starting early, keeping it simple, and not interrupting time.

00

Mindset & money

Before the charts and the complicated names, what counts is the right relationship with risk, time and your goals.



IN THIS MODULE

-
- | | | |
|---|--------------------------------|-------|
| 1 | Why saving isn't enough | 4 min |
| 2 | Risk and time: your two allies | 5 min |
-

01 Why saving isn't enough

Saving is the foundation of everything. Without a reserve, any surprise turns into debt. But there is a silent problem: money sitting in an account loses buying power year after year. That is called inflation — and it is why saving, on its own, is not enough.

€1,000 sitting idle, over 10 years

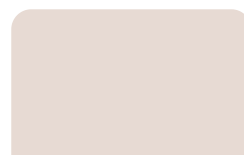
~2.5%/yr average inflation

€1,000



Today

~€781



In 10 years

Even without spending a cent, what that money buys shrinks. Illustrative figures.

The answer is not to stop saving — it is to split money by purpose. One part stays liquid, for emergencies and near-term goals. Another part, the money you will not need soon, can be invested to grow above inflation.

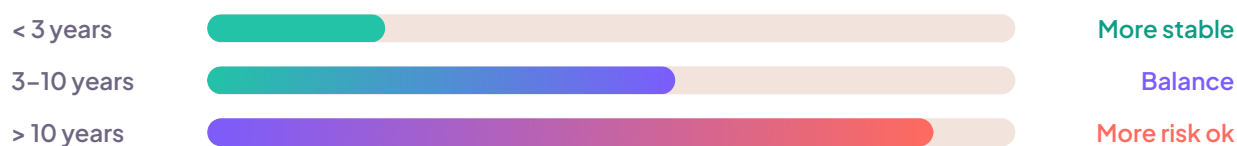
KEY IDEA

Saving keeps your money; investing stops inflation from eating it.

02 Risk and time: your two allies

Risk is scary, but it is not the enemy — it is the price of any return above inflation. The trick is to pair it with your time horizon: the further away the goal, the more ups and downs you can ride out along the way.

How long until you need the money?



With more time, there is room to recover from drops — which is why the horizon changes what makes sense.

EXAMPLE

Money for a car in 2 years asks for stability.
Money for retirement, 30 years out, can take far more swing.

CAUTION

Too much risk for a near-term goal can force you to sell at the worst moment. Always match it to the timeframe.

What you take from this module

- 1 Saving is the base, but idle money loses value to inflation. Investing is how your money grows above it.
- 2 Risk is not the enemy — it is the price of return. What makes it sensible (or not) is your time horizon.
- 3 Split money by purpose: a liquid reserve for the short term, invested money for the long term.

TERMS IN THIS MODULE

Inflation

Time horizon

Liquidity

Emergency fund



A QUESTION FOR YOU

Which part of your money won't you truly need in the next five years?

01

Fundamentals

The core ideas that hold up everything else — compound interest, inflation, and the link between liquidity and time.

IN THIS MODULE

- | | | |
|---|-------------------------------------|-------|
| 1 | Compound interest, explained calmly | 5 min |
| 2 | Inflation: the invisible tax | 4 min |
| 3 | Liquidity and time horizon | 4 min |

01 Compound interest, explained calmly

It is the most powerful idea of all — and the simplest. Compound interest is earning a return not only on what you invested, but also on the return that has already built up. Gains start generating their own gains.



Notice the curve: at the start it barely differs from a straight line. It only takes off near the end. That is why the most valuable ingredient is not having a lot of money — it is giving **time** to the process.

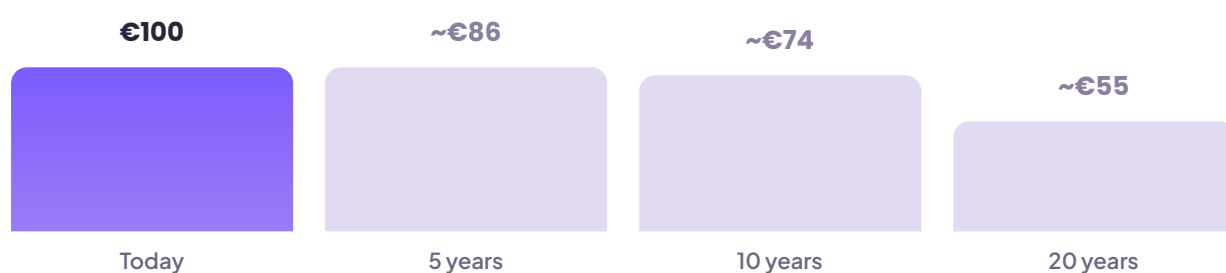
KEY IDEA

Time is the engine of compound interest. Starting early is worth more than starting big.

02 Inflation: the invisible tax

Nobody charges you inflation directly, but it takes buying power from you every year. If prices rise 3% and your money sits idle, you became 3% poorer without spending a thing. It is the tax that never shows on a receipt.

What €100 buys over time (inflation ~3%/yr)



EXAMPLE

A €1 coffee today will cost close to €1.34 in 10 years at 3% inflation. The price went up; your idle money did not.

CAUTION

"I didn't lose money, it's all in the account" is an illusion. In buying power, idle money almost always loses.

03 Liquidity and time horizon

Liquidity is how quickly you can turn something into cash without losing value. Money in an account is very liquid; property is not. Cross this with your horizon and you see where to place each euro.

From most to least liquid

Account / deposit	Bonds	Equities	Property
Instant	Days	Days	Months

The less liquid it is, the more time (and patience) the asset tends to ask for.

Rule of thumb: money you might need at any moment stays liquid; money with years ahead can go to less-liquid assets, which tend to reward that wait.

KEY IDEA

Pair liquidity and horizon: near money liquid and stable; distant money put to work.

What you take from this module

- 1 Compound interest makes gains generate gains. The curve takes off at the end, so time is the most valuable ingredient.
- 2 Inflation erodes idle money every year. Investing is how you try to grow above it.
- 3 Liquidity and horizon go together: short-term money stays accessible; long-term money can earn more.

TERMS IN THIS MODULE

Compound interest

Inflation

Buying power

Liquidity



A QUESTION FOR YOU

If you started today with little, but every month, where would you be in 20 years?

02

Asset classes

The big families where you can put your money — equities, bonds, cash and the alternatives.

IN THIS MODULE

- | | | |
|---|------------------------------------|-------|
| 1 | Global equities: owning companies | 6 min |
| 2 | Bonds: lending with rules | 5 min |
| 3 | Cash, real estate and alternatives | 5 min |

01 Global equities: owning companies

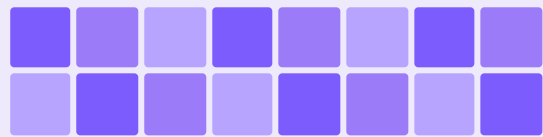
A share is a slice of a company. If it grows and makes a profit, you — as a part-owner — benefit. Instead of betting on a single company, you can own thousands at once through a global index.

One share vs. a global index



1 company

Everything depends on it



Thousands of companies

The risk is diluted

Historically, equities are the class that grows most over the long run — but also the one that swings most along the way. It is the premium you pay for enduring volatility.

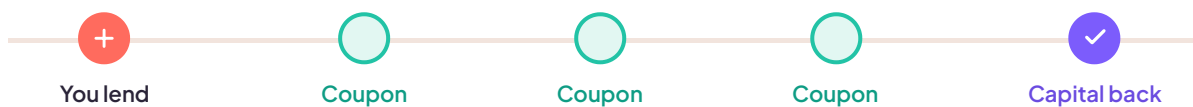
KEY IDEA

Owning many companies at once dilutes the risk of any single one going wrong.

02 Bonds: lending with rules

Buying a bond is lending money to a government or company. In return you receive periodic interest (the coupon) and, at the end, your capital back. More predictable than equities — and so it usually swings less.

How it works, over time



EXAMPLE

You lend to a government for 5 years. You receive an annual coupon and, at maturity, the amount you lent returns.

CAUTION

"Predictable" is not "risk-free": who pays you can default, and the value moves with interest rates.

03 Cash, real estate and alternatives

Beyond equities and bonds, there are other families with specific roles. They are not required to start, but it is worth knowing what they do — and what they ask in return.



Cash / liquidity

Deposits and money-market funds. Stable and accessible; earns little. It is your cushion.



Real estate

Rent and potential appreciation. Illiquid and capital-heavy; also via listed funds.



Gold and commodities

They tend to move differently from the rest. They pay no income; they act as a counterweight.



Crypto and others

Very volatile and speculative. If they come in, only with a small slice and money you can afford to lose.

KEY IDEA

To start, equities and bonds are enough. Alternatives are seasoning, not the main dish.

What you take from this module

- 1 Equities are slices of companies: more long-term return, more swing. A global index dilutes the risk of any single one.
- 2 Bonds are loans with interest: more predictable and stable, but not free of risk.
- 3 Cash, real estate and alternatives have specific roles — useful in small doses, not at the centre.

TERMS IN THIS MODULE

Share

Index

Bond

Coupon

Volatility



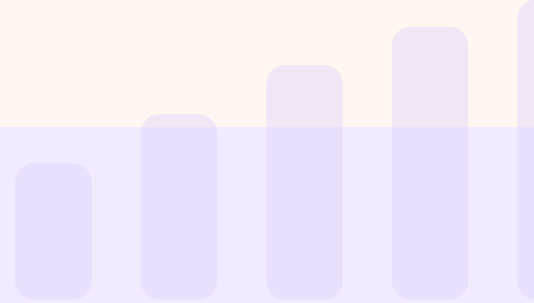
A QUESTION FOR YOU

Between growing more (and swinging) or sleeping soundly, where do you feel comfortable?

03

Diversification & portfolios

How simple pieces — combined thoughtfully — form a whole more robust than any single bet.



IN THIS MODULE

- | | | |
|---|----------------------------------|-------|
| 1 | Don't put all eggs in one basket | 5 min |
| 2 | How a balanced portfolio is born | 6 min |

01 Don't put all eggs in one basket

To diversify is to spread money across things that don't rise and fall all at the same time. When one fails, another holds. It doesn't remove risk — but it softens the jolts.

All in one vs. spread out

CONCENTRATED



Rises a lot, falls a lot. Everything rides on one bet.

DIVERSIFIED



A smoother path. Some falls offset with others.

You diversify in layers: across classes (equities, bonds), within each class (many companies, several countries) and over time. The good news: a single global index fund already brings much of this diversification out of the box.

KEY IDEA

Diversifying doesn't maximise one year's gain — it makes the journey of many years more bearable.

02 How a balanced portfolio is born

A portfolio is just the mix of classes you choose. The big decision — the allocation — is how much you put in each. More equities pull for growth; more bonds and cash calm the swings.

Three illustrative profiles



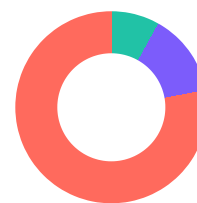
Cautious

Short horizon



Balanced

Medium horizon



Bold

Long horizon

■ Equities ■ Bonds ■ Cash

EXAMPLE

A widely cited starting rule: the percentage in bonds near your age. A starting point, not a law.

CAUTION

There is no universal "right" portfolio. The best one is the one you can keep through the bad years.

What you take from this module

- 1** Diversifying is spreading across things that don't all fall at once. It smooths the journey without removing risk.
- 2** The allocation — how much you put in each class — is the decision that most defines the portfolio's behaviour.
- 3** The best portfolio is the one you can keep through the bad years — not the one that looks perfect on paper.

TERMS IN THIS MODULE

Diversification

Portfolio

Allocation

Rebalancing



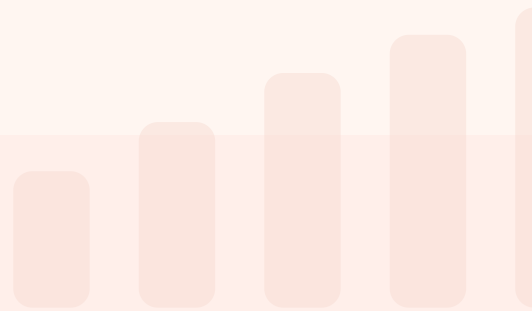
A QUESTION FOR YOU

In a 20% drop, could you avoid touching your portfolio for a whole year?

04

In practice

The quiet habits that make a plan work over the years. Less emotion, more system.



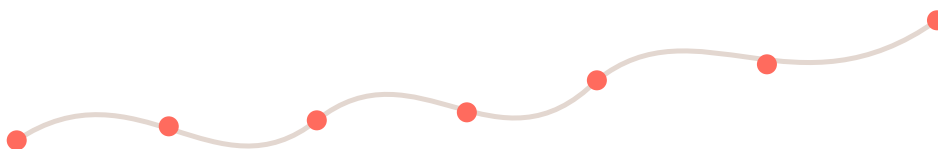
IN THIS MODULE

- | | | |
|---|------------------------------------|-------|
| 1 | Investing regularly | 4 min |
| 2 | Costs and taxes, without headaches | 5 min |

01 Investing regularly

Investing the same amount, at fixed intervals, is called regular investing. You buy more when it's cheap and less when it's dear — without having to guess the right moment. The habit does the heavy lifting.

The same amount, month after month



Each dot is a purchase. The market goes up and down; you keep going, always the same.

The biggest advantage is behavioural: you automate the decision and take emotion out of the path. Set it once and let it run. Consistency almost always beats trying to guess the "best day".

KEY IDEA

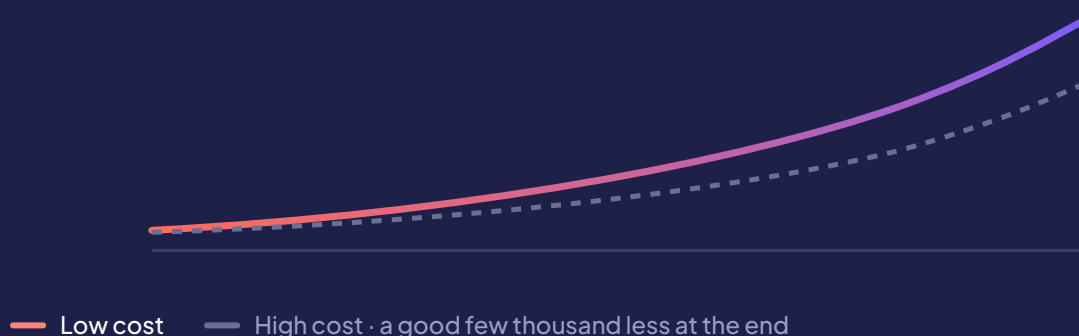
Time in the market almost always beats trying to time the market.

02 Costs and taxes, without headaches

Costs are one of the few factors you control 100%. An annual fee that looks small, year after year, eats a huge slice of the final result. It is worth understanding them before you start.

How much a 1% annual fee weighs

30 years · illustrative



EXAMPLE

Always compare a fund's annual fee (TER). The gap between 0.2% and 1.5% is enormous after decades.

CAUTION

There are also taxes on gains and transaction costs. The rules depend on the country — check your own jurisdiction.

Simple rule: pay as little as possible in fees, avoid buying and selling all the time, and understand how gains are taxed where you live.

What you take from this module

- 1 Investing the same amount regularly takes emotion and guessing out of the equation. The habit does the work.
- 2 Costs are one of the few factors you control. Low fees, after years, are worth a lot of money.
- 3 Learn about taxes where you live and avoid over-trading — every move has a cost.

TERMS IN THIS MODULE

Regular investing

Fee (TER)

Automation



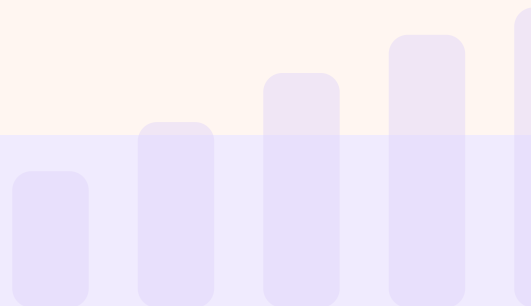
A QUESTION FOR YOU

What monthly amount could you automate today, without missing it?

05

Behaviour

Keeping a cool head when markets shake —
because the biggest risk, often, is you.



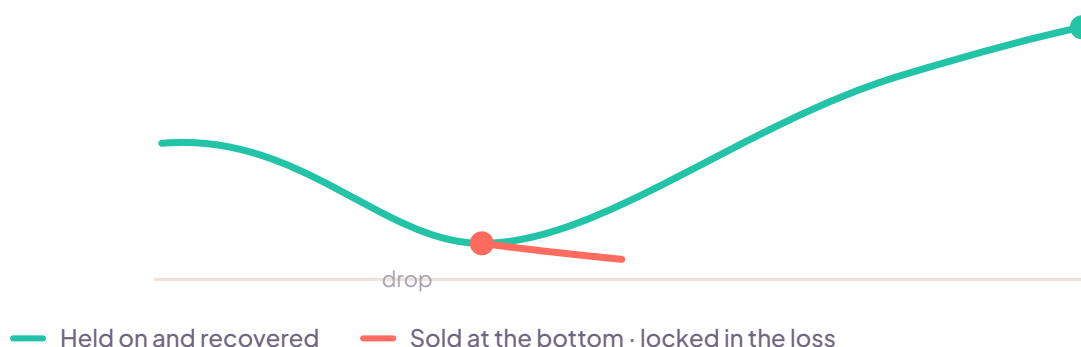
IN THIS MODULE

- | | | |
|---|--|-------|
| 1 | How not to panic in a downturn | 5 min |
| 2 | The most common mistakes (and how to avoid them) | 5 min |

01 How not to panic in a downturn

Drops are part of it. They happen, they recover, they happen again. The costly mistake is not the drop — it is selling at the bottom, turning a temporary loss into a permanent one.

Who holds vs. who sells at the bottom



The defence is built *before*: keep an emergency fund (so you don't need to sell), choose an allocation you can bear, and agree with yourself not to make big decisions mid-fright.

KEY IDEA

A drop only becomes a real loss when you sell. Those who don't need to sell, wait.

02 The most common mistakes (and how to avoid them)

Almost nobody fails for lack of information — they fail by repeating the same slips. Know them in advance and you're halfway there.



Trying to time the market

Nobody does it consistently. Antidote: regular, automatic contributions.



Chasing what rose most

Buying at the top of a fad usually ends up costing. Antidote: a defined plan and diversification.



Tinkering with the portfolio constantly

More costs, more mistakes, more stress. Antidote: review a few times a year, with rules.



Investing without an emergency fund

Forces you to sell at the worst moment. Antidote: build the cushion before investing.

What you take from this module

- 1** Drops are normal and recover. The costly mistake is selling at the bottom and turning a temporary loss into a permanent one.
- 2** The defence is built before the storm: emergency fund, a bearable allocation, and rules decided calmly.
- 3** Common mistakes are predictable — timing, fads, over-tinkering. Knowing them is half the solution.

TERMS IN THIS MODULE

Volatility

Correction

Behavioural bias



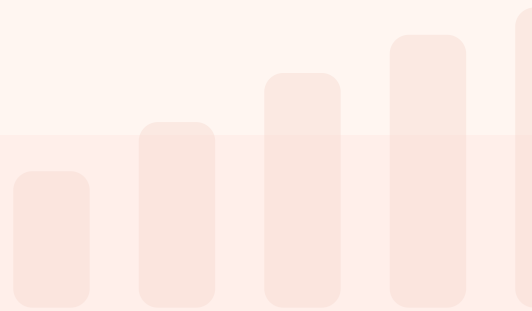
A QUESTION FOR YOU

What will your written rule be for the days the market plunges?

06

Your plan

Everything you've seen so far condensed into a simple plan, written by you, that fits on one page.



IN THIS MODULE

- | | | |
|---|------------------------|-------|
| 1 | Define your goals | 4 min |
| 2 | Put it all on one page | 5 min |

01 Define your goals

Investing without a goal is rowing without direction. Before the "where", answer the "what for" and the "when". It is the goal and the timeframe that set how much risk makes sense — not the other way around.

A good goal has four pieces



What for

Retirement, a home, breathing room...



When

The horizon: 3, 10, 30 years?



How much

The target amount, even if rough.



How much risk

What you can bear without losing sleep.

You can have several goals at once, each with its own timeframe and allocation. The short-term one, more stable; the long-term one, with more room to grow.

KEY IDEA

Goal and timeframe first. Risk and assets are a consequence, not the starting point.

02 Put it all on one page

Fill in these fields and you have your investment plan on a single sheet.
Simple to keep, easy to re-read on a panic day.



My investment plan

MY GOAL

HORIZON (YEARS)

EMERGENCY FUND (MONTHS)

AMOUNT TO INVEST PER MONTH

MY TARGET ALLOCATION


Equities
____ %


Bonds
____ %


Cash
____ %

MY RULE FOR DOWN DAYS

What you take from this module

- 1 The goal and timeframe come first. They decide the risk and the assets — never the other way around.
- 2 A plan that fits on one page is easier to keep — and to re-read when emotions run high.
- 3 Define your rule for the bad days while you're calm. Your future self will thank you.

TERMS IN THIS MODULE

Financial goal

Target allocation

Investment plan



A QUESTION FOR YOU

Have you filled in your plan sheet yet? If not, that's your next step.

Common myths about investing

Much of what holds people back is simply false. Here are five clichés — and what actually happens.

MYTH

"It's only for the rich"

ACTUALLY

Today you start with a few euros a month. What matters is regularity and time, not the initial amount.

MYTH

"I need to know how to pick stocks"

ACTUALLY

A global index fund gives you thousands of companies at once. You don't need to guess winners.

MYTH

"It's like going to a casino"

ACTUALLY

Betting is short-term all-or-nothing. Diversified long-term investing is the opposite: patience and the odds on your side.

MYTH

"I have to watch it every day"

ACTUALLY

Looking every day only feeds anxiety. A good plan works best when you leave it alone.

MYTH

"I have to wait for the right moment"

ACTUALLY

The "right moment" is only known afterwards. Starting early and regularly beats, almost always, waiting for the perfect day.

Glossary

THE KEY WORDS, IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Allocation

How money is split across asset classes. The decision that most defines the portfolio's behaviour.

Bond

A loan to a government or company. They pay you interest and return the capital at maturity.

Compound interest

Earning a return on prior returns too. The effect takes off with time.

Coupon

The periodic interest a bond pays to whoever holds it.

Diversification

Spreading money across assets that don't rise and fall all at once, to smooth the journey.

Dividend

Part of the profit a company distributes to shareholders.

ETF / Index fund

A basket that tracks a whole index. Buy one and you're exposed to hundreds or thousands of companies.

Inflation

The general rise in prices over time. It makes idle money lose buying power.

Glossary

CONTINUED

Index

A basket representing a market (e.g. the largest companies in the world). A reference and the base for index funds.

Liquidity

How quickly you can turn an asset into cash without losing value. Cash is very liquid; property, not.

Buying power

What your money actually buys. This — not the number in the account — is what inflation erodes.

Portfolio

The set of all your investments, seen as a whole.

Rebalancing

Adjusting the portfolio back to the target allocation when one class has grown too much vs. the others.

Regular investing

Investing the same amount at fixed intervals, regardless of price. Takes emotion out of the decision.

Return

The gain (or loss) of an investment, usually as a percentage per year.

Risk

The uncertainty of the outcome — including the chance of losing money. It is the price of any return above inflation.

Glossary

CONTINUED

Emergency fund

Liquid money for the unexpected (typically a few months of expenses). Avoids having to sell investments at the worst moment.

Share

A slice of ownership in a company. If it grows and profits, you benefit as a part-owner.

TER / Fee

A fund's annual cost, as a percentage. Small at a glance, huge after decades. Always compare.

Time horizon

The time until you need the money. It sets how much risk is reasonable to take.

Volatility

The ups and downs of an asset's value. More volatility isn't bankruptcy — it's a bumpy road.

NOTE

You'll find these and other words explained with examples in the interactive glossary in the HowToInvest app — always in plain language, no jargon.

Your first steps

Knowing is half of it; the other half is doing. Here is a simple sequence to move from reading to action — no rush.

- 1 Secure your **emergency fund** before investing.
- 2 Write down **goal, timeframe and monthly amount** on your plan sheet.
- 3 Set your **target allocation** according to your horizon.
- 4 **Automate** regular contributions and keep costs low.
- 5 **Stay the course** and re-read your plan on down days.



CONTINUE IN THE APP

Discover your profile and follow the guided path

Point your camera at the code to open HowToInvest. A profile quiz, modules and an interactive glossary — free and with no products for sale.

Starting is the hardest step.

You took it by reading this far. Now it is about keeping it simple, regular and patient. Time handles the rest.

No products. No promises.

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